Physical Activity & Healthy Living in India

A practical, inclusive guide for all 28 states and 8 union territories — including Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh

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Prepared as an evidence-informed educational synthesis using WHO physical activity guidance and ICMR–NIN Dietary Guidelines for Indians (2024). Regional examples are adaptations, not separate state-government prescriptions.

How to use this guide

- Start with your age group and health status, then choose the safest feasible activities in your environment.
- Use the state/UT directory for climate, terrain and cultural examples; activity targets do not change by state.
- If you have symptoms, a new medical condition, pregnancy-related complications or significant disability, adapt with a qualified clinician or physiotherapist.
- Progress gradually: a small sustainable amount is better than doing nothing.

1 | The foundation: what counts as physical activity?

Physical activity includes movement at work, home, in transport and during recreation. Exercise is planned physical activity. Walking to shops, gardening, climbing stairs, household chores, cycling, dancing, swimming, yoga and strength training may all contribute. The intensity and duration determine how much activity counts toward aerobic targets.

Moderate intensity: breathing faster but still able to talk in sentences (talk test). Vigorous: breathing hard; only a few words comfortably. These descriptions are approximate and may be altered by medication, altitude, heat or illness.

2 | Age-specific recommendations

Population	Core recommendation	Additional guidance
Under 1 year	Frequent supervised floor-based active play; for non-mobile infants, tummy time totaling at least 30 min/day while awake	Never leave infants unattended or asleep prone; follow WHO under-5 guidance.
1–2 years	At least 180 min/day of varied physical activity at any intensity	Spread through the day; avoid prolonged restraint.
3–4 years	At least 180 min/day, including at least 60 min energetic play	Spread through the day; prioritize safe outdoor or indoor play.
5–17 years	Average ≥60 min/day moderate-to-vigorous activity, mostly aerobic, across the week	Vigorous and muscle/bone-strengthening activity ≥3 days/week.
18–64 years	150–300 min/week moderate aerobic OR 75–150 min/week vigorous OR equivalent combination	Strengthen all major muscle groups ≥2 days/week; limit sedentary time.
65+ years	Same aerobic and strength targets as adults, adjusted to ability	Multicomponent balance/functional strength ≥3 days/week; fall prevention.
Pregnancy/postpartum	For uncomplicated	Include strengthening, adapt to

	pregnancy/postpartum: ≥150 min/week moderate aerobic	symptoms and obstetric advice; avoid risky activities.
Disability/chronic conditions	Aim toward age-appropriate targets where safe and feasible	Adapt modes and intensity; some movement is better than none.

Sources: WHO 2020 physical activity and sedentary behaviour guideline; WHO guidelines on physical activity, sedentary behaviour and sleep for children under 5 (2019).

3 | What exercise improves — and what it does not guarantee

Type	Examples in India	Benefits
Aerobic	Brisk walking, cycling, swimming, jogging, dancing, active commuting	Cardiorespiratory fitness, blood pressure, glucose regulation, mood and endurance
Strength	Chair squats, wall push-ups, resistance bands, dumbbells, machines, carrying loads safely	Muscle strength, function, bone health, healthy ageing
Balance	Heel-to-toe walk near support, single-leg stance with support, tai chi-like movement	Reduced fall risk when combined with functional training
Mobility/flexibility	Gentle stretching, mobility drills, yoga asanas	Joint range and comfort; not a replacement for aerobic and strength training
Sports/play	Kabaddi, kho-kho, badminton, football, cricket with active running, folk dance	Social engagement, fitness and enjoyment; actual intensity varies

Physical activity can reduce health risks but cannot replace needed medication, medical evaluation, sleep or adequate nutrition. Fat loss depends on overall energy balance; no exercise selectively burns fat from one body part.

4 | Safe start: screening and warning signs

- If inactive, start with 5–10 minutes of comfortable walking or equivalent most days, then build duration and frequency before intensity.
- Warm up 5–10 minutes with easy movement; cool down with easy movement. Choose stable footwear and safe surfaces.
- Stop activity and seek urgent medical help for chest pain/pressure, fainting, severe breathlessness, new one-sided weakness, severe headache or confusion.
- Seek clinical advice for exertional dizziness, unusual palpitations, worsening joint pain, unexplained breathlessness or recent significant illness.
- Do not exercise intensely during fever or significant dehydration. Resume gradually after illness.
- Avoid comparing step counts between people: ability, disability, occupation and device accuracy differ.

5 | Sample weekly activity plans

A. Beginner adult, no known contraindication

Day	Activity	Suggested dose
Mon	Brisk or comfortable walk + chair squats	20 min + 2 × 8
Tue	Walk + mobility	20 min + 10 min
Wed	Walk + wall push-ups + band rows	25 min + 2 × 8 each
Thu	Easy cycling or walking	20 min
Fri	Walk + sit-to-stand + calf raises	25 min + 2 × 10

Sat	Recreational dance, hike or active errands	30 min
Sun	Recovery walk and gentle stretching	15–20 min

This is a starting example, not yet a full 150-minute moderate-intensity prescription for everyone. Gradually increase toward guideline targets as tolerated.

B. Adult meeting the WHO minimum

Example: brisk walk 30 minutes on Monday through Friday (150 min/week), plus 20–40 minutes of full-body resistance training on two nonconsecutive days. For strength, use 1–3 sets of 8–12 controlled repetitions per movement, selecting an effort that preserves technique. Sets/reps are practical coaching examples, not WHO-prescribed numbers.

C. Older adult balance-oriented plan

Walk or equivalent most days as tolerated; 2 days of strength (chair rises, supported rows, calf raises); at least 3 days of balance work near a stable support. Avoid unsupported balance challenges if fall risk is high. Seek physiotherapy assessment for recent falls.

D. School-age child

Combine walking/cycling to school where safe, playground games, running, dance and sport to average 60 minutes/day across the week. Include jumping, climbing and muscle/bone-strengthening play on at least three days; avoid treating children as miniature adult gym trainees.

6 | Climate, air, terrain and season: India-specific decisions

Context	Practical adaptation	Avoid / caution
Hot, humid coastal summers	Early morning/evening, shaded routes, ventilated indoor sessions, gradual heat acclimatization, fluids	Midday strenuous outdoor workouts; ignore no heat-illness symptoms
Dry extreme heat	Cooler hours, indoor alternatives, frequent rest, water access	Exertion during heat alerts; unacclimatized high intensity
Monsoon/flooding	Indoor walking, stairs with safe rails, bodyweight training, covered community spaces	Floodwater, slippery trails, lightning exposure
Severe winter/snow	Indoor circuits, layers, safe traction, longer warm-up	Icy roads, exertion during extreme cold without protection
High altitude	Allow acclimatization, start at lower intensity, recognize headache/nausea/dizziness	Rapid ascent and strenuous activity with altitude-illness symptoms
Poor air quality/smoke	Check local AQI; move vigorous exercise indoors with cleaner air where feasible	Hard outdoor exertion during severe pollution episodes
Remote/rural settings	Walking, farm-task movement, household resistance exercises, local games	Assuming strenuous work substitutes for all strength/balance needs

AQI actions should follow local public-health advisories, especially for children, pregnant people and those with heart/lung disease. Occupational exertion may already be high; prioritize recovery and complementary movement rather than adding excessive volume.

7 | Every state and union territory: local activity options

These are illustrative, locally adaptable options and common environmental considerations; they are not claims about all residents or district-specific epidemiology. The same national/WHO activity targets apply across regions.

1. Andhra Pradesh

Environmental consideration: Coastal heat and seasonal rain.

Accessible activity examples: Early walks, cycling, badminton, indoor strength.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

2. Arunachal Pradesh

Environmental consideration: Mountain slopes, rain, remote terrain.

Accessible activity examples: Safe graded walks, indoor resistance, community games.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

3. Assam

Environmental consideration: Humid weather, monsoon and flooding.

Accessible activity examples: Covered walking, indoor dance, cycling on safe routes.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

4. Bihar

Environmental consideration: Hot summers, foggy winters in some areas.

Accessible activity examples: Morning walks in safe weather, chair circuits, local sports.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

5. Chhattisgarh

Environmental consideration: Hot season and forested/rural areas.

Accessible activity examples: Shaded walking, resistance bands, active games.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

6. Goa

Environmental consideration: Coastal humidity and monsoon.

Accessible activity examples: Swimming with supervision, beach walks on safe surfaces, indoor strength.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

7. Gujarat

Environmental consideration: Dry heat, coastal variation.

Accessible activity examples: Cool-hour walking, cycling, indoor workouts.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

8. Haryana

Environmental consideration: Hot summers and cool winters.

Accessible activity examples: Walking, kabaddi-style recreation, strength training.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

9. Himachal Pradesh

Environmental consideration: Hills, snow/ice in higher regions.

Accessible activity examples: Hill walks graded to ability, balance and winter indoor workouts.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

10. Jharkhand

Environmental consideration: Hot season, plateau terrain.

Accessible activity examples: Walking, community sports, strength circuits.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

11. Karnataka

Environmental consideration: Urban traffic and varied elevation/climate.

Accessible activity examples: Park walking, cycling where safe, indoor resistance.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

12. Kerala

Environmental consideration: Humid climate and heavy monsoon.

Accessible activity examples: Swimming safely, indoor walking, yoga plus aerobic work.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

13. Madhya Pradesh

Environmental consideration: Hot summers and varied rural/urban access.

Accessible activity examples: Early walks, active commuting, bodyweight strength.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

14. Maharashtra

Environmental consideration: Urban pollution/traffic, coastal humidity, plateau heat.

Accessible activity examples: Indoor/outdoor walking by AQI, stair circuits, sports.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

15. Manipur

Environmental consideration: Hills and wet season.

Accessible activity examples: Dance, walking on safe paths, indoor strengthening.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

16. Meghalaya

Environmental consideration: Heavy rainfall and slippery slopes.

Accessible activity examples: Covered walking, balance training, indoor circuits.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

17. Mizoram

Environmental consideration: Steep hills and monsoon.

Accessible activity examples: Graded hill walking, supported strength, indoor dance.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

18. Nagaland

Environmental consideration: Hills and rainy season.

Accessible activity examples: Trail walking only on safe paths, strength and balance.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

19. Odisha

Environmental consideration: Heat, humidity, cyclones/monsoon.

Accessible activity examples: Cool-hour walks, indoor activity during weather alerts.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

20. Punjab

Environmental consideration: Hot summers, winter fog in places.

Accessible activity examples: Walking, cycling safely, resistance exercise.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

21. Rajasthan

Environmental consideration: Extreme heat and arid zones.

Accessible activity examples: Cool-hour/indoor walking, hydration, low-equipment strength.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

22. Sikkim

Environmental consideration: Altitude, steep paths and wet season.

Accessible activity examples: Acclimatized walks, balance, indoor strength.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

23. Tamil Nadu

Environmental consideration: Heat/humidity, urban traffic, coastal conditions.

Accessible activity examples: Early walks, swimming safely, indoor resistance.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

24. Telangana

Environmental consideration: Hot season, urban heat.

Accessible activity examples: Early walking, cycling where safe, gym or home strength.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

25. Tripura

Environmental consideration: Humid monsoon and hilly terrain.

Accessible activity examples: Covered walking, active games, balance work.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

26. Uttar Pradesh

Environmental consideration: Summer heat, winter fog and urban pollution.

Accessible activity examples: AQI-aware walking, indoor strength, active household routines.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

27. Uttarakhand

Environmental consideration: Mountain terrain, landslides and winter cold.

Accessible activity examples: Graded hiking when safe, balance, indoor circuits.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

28. West Bengal

Environmental consideration: Humid coastal and cooler northern zones.

Accessible activity examples: Walking, dance, cycling safely, indoor monsoon options.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

29. Andaman and Nicobar Islands

Environmental consideration: Tropical heat, humidity and heavy rain.

Accessible activity examples: Walking, swimming with water-safety precautions, indoor workouts.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

30. Chandigarh

Environmental consideration: Urban parks, hot summers, winter air issues.

Accessible activity examples: Park walking by AQI, cycling lanes, gym/home strength.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

31. Dadra and Nagar Haveli and Daman and Diu

Environmental consideration: Coastal humidity and inland heat.

Accessible activity examples: Early walking, indoor strength, safe recreation.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

32. Delhi (NCT)

Environmental consideration: Severe seasonal air pollution and heat.

Accessible activity examples: AQI-responsive indoor exercise, shaded walking on suitable days.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

33. Jammu and Kashmir

Environmental consideration: Kashmir Valley winters/snow, Jammu summer heat, hilly areas.

Accessible activity examples: Kashmir: indoor winter circuits and safe seasonal walking; Jammu: cool-hour summer exercise; all areas: balance/strength.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

34. Ladakh

Environmental consideration: High altitude, cold and low oxygen availability.

Accessible activity examples: Acclimatization, lower initial effort, indoor winter training; urgent evaluation for altitude illness.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

35. Lakshadweep

Environmental consideration: Tropical humidity and limited land area.

Accessible activity examples: Walking loops, safe swimming, home strength.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

36. Puducherry

Environmental consideration: Coastal humidity and monsoon.

Accessible activity examples: Early walks, safe cycling, indoor resistance.

Practical rule: use the age-appropriate national target, adjust for individual health, local weather, access, safety and preference.

8 | Kashmir and Ladakh: focused practical guidance

Kashmir Valley (Jammu & Kashmir)

Winter snow, cold and slippery roads can limit outdoor activity. Use indoor walking, stairs with rails, chair squats, wall push-ups, resistance bands, dance and mobility circuits. In milder months, walking in parks or on safe paths and cycling where safe can contribute. Winter indoor plans should still include aerobic activity plus strength, not stretching alone.

Jammu region (Jammu & Kashmir)

During very hot periods, favor cooler hours, shade and ventilated indoor options; in hills, consider terrain, landslides and cold conditions. Adjust walking speed to breathing and heat tolerance rather than rigid step targets.

Ladakh

High altitude can cause acute mountain sickness and more severe illness. New arrivals should acclimatize before strenuous exertion. Worsening headache, vomiting, breathlessness at rest, confusion or impaired coordination warrant urgent medical evaluation and descent/oxygen where available. Do not treat altitude symptoms as ordinary lack of fitness.

9 | Exercise for common health goals

Goal	Activity emphasis	What to monitor
Heart and metabolic health	Regular moderate aerobic activity + strength	Weekly minutes, BP/glucose if clinically indicated, exertional symptoms
Fat loss	Aerobic activity + strength + sustainable nutrition habits	Waist, trends in weight, energy, function; avoid extreme deficits
Healthy weight gain	Progressive strength + adequate nutrition	Strength progression, weight trend, appetite, medical causes of unexplained low weight
Muscle maintenance	Full-body resistance ≥2 days/week	Movement quality, load, repetitions, recovery
Bone health	Appropriate weight-bearing and resistance work	Falls, fracture history, osteoporosis restrictions
Stress/sleep	Consistent enjoyable activity, outdoor light when appropriate	Sleep, mood, fatigue; avoid intense activity if it disrupts sleep
Mobility and independence	Strength, balance and functional	Chair-rise ability, safe gait, falls

tasks

10 | Adaptation for medical conditions and life stages

- Diabetes: aerobic and resistance activity are useful; people using insulin or sulfonylureas may need glucose monitoring and a hypoglycemia plan. Check foot problems and complications.
- Hypertension: exercise is beneficial; uncontrolled or symptomatic blood pressure needs clinician assessment before vigorous activity. Avoid breath-holding during lifting.
- Heart disease: follow clinician guidance or cardiac rehabilitation after recent cardiac events; stop for chest discomfort or concerning symptoms.
- Asthma/COPD: use individualized inhaler/action plans and appropriate warm-up; severe symptoms require medical review.
- Osteoarthritis: low-impact aerobic movement and strength often help; adjust to pain, function and flare-ups.
- Osteoporosis: prioritize safe strength and balance; vertebral fracture risk may require avoidance of loaded spinal flexion.
- Pregnancy: uncomplicated pregnancies generally benefit from moderate activity; seek obstetric advice for bleeding, dizziness, chest pain, fluid leakage, painful contractions or other warning signs.
- Disability: accessible movement, wheelchair propulsion, seated aerobics and adaptive resistance can count. Plan around individual function and equipment.
- Older adults: functional strength, balance and fall prevention are essential; avoid unsupported risky drills.
- People with eating disorders or unexplained weight loss: do not prescribe exercise for calorie compensation; prioritize clinical evaluation.

11 | Everyday nutrition, hydration and recovery

Use a varied diet including vegetables, fruit, pulses/legumes, whole grains/millets, nuts and suitable protein sources, consistent with ICMR–NIN 2024 guidance. Match food and fluid intake to climate, work, activity and health conditions. In heat, access to drinking water and rest is important; people with heart/kidney conditions may have fluid restrictions. Sleep and recovery matter as much as workout intensity. Supplements are not necessary for most beginners.

12 | Tracking progress without obsession

Measure	Useful approach	Limitation
Activity minutes	Weekly moderate/vigorous minutes	Intensity estimates can be imperfect
Strength	Record sets/reps/load and technique	Not directly comparable across people
Daily steps	Optional personal baseline and gradual increase	No universal mandatory 10,000-step target
Resting pulse/BP	Track when medically relevant	Wearables may be inaccurate
Waist/weight	Optional longer-term trend	Fluctuates with fluid, menstrual cycle and illness
Function	Stairs, walking tolerance, chair rises	Often more meaningful than body weight alone
Wellbeing	Sleep, mood, energy, enjoyment	Self-report changes are subjective

13 | Four-week starter progression

Week	Aerobic activity	Strength/balance

1	10–15 min comfortable activity on 5 days	1–2 sessions, basic technique
2	15–20 min on 5 days if tolerated	2 sessions, 1–2 sets
3	20–25 min on 5 days if tolerated	2 sessions, 1–3 sets
4	25–30 min on 5 days if tolerated	2 sessions; add balance if needed

Progression is illustrative. People with disability, chronic disease, significant deconditioning or physically demanding work may need a slower or different plan.

14 | Frequently asked questions

Is yoga enough?

Yoga supports mobility, balance, strength and wellbeing; depending on intensity, it may not provide sufficient moderate aerobic activity. Combine with walking/cycling or other aerobic exercise.

Can household chores count?

Yes, when movement is of sufficient intensity; all movement still has value even below moderate intensity.

Is 10,000 steps compulsory?

No. It is not a WHO requirement. Start from your own baseline and build gradually.

Can I exercise during periods?

Usually yes if comfortable; adjust to symptoms. Severe pain, heavy bleeding or dizziness merits medical advice.

Is gym equipment necessary?

No. Walking, stairs, chair squats, push-up variations and bands can provide substantial benefit.

Can children lift weights?

Age-appropriate supervised resistance training with technique and appropriate loads can be safe; avoid maximal unsupervised lifting.

What if I have no time?

Short bouts count. Try 5–10 minute walks and active breaks, building weekly totals.

Does sweating mean fat loss?

No. Sweating primarily reflects heat regulation and fluid loss, not the amount of body fat lost.

15 | Sources and evidence notes

WHO 2020 physical activity and sedentary behaviour guidelines — https://www.who.int/publications/i/item/9789240015128

WHO guideline summary (2020) — https://www.who.int/publications/i/item/9789240014886

WHO physical activity/sleep for children under 5 (2019) — https://www.who.int/publications/i/item/9789241550536

ICMR–NIN Dietary Guidelines for Indians (2024) — https://www.nin.res.in/dietaryguidelines/pdfjs/locale/DGI07052024P.pdf

Ministry of Home Affairs: Union Territories — https://www.mha.gov.in/union-territories-divisions

Ministry of Home Affairs: Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh — https://www.mha.gov.in/jammu-kashmir-ladakh-affairs

Evidence classification: age-group activity volumes and frequency are based on WHO recommendations; nutrition framing on ICMR–NIN; region-specific examples and sample routines are practical editorial adaptations, not state-issued guidelines. This document does not make unsupported state-level disease prevalence claims.

Safety disclaimer: This is public health education, not diagnosis, medical clearance or a substitute for individualized clinical advice. Public recommendations should be adapted by qualified clinicians when symptoms, contraindications or complex conditions are present.